

Burners Sorcerie

Magic — how a Sorcerer prepares, carries, and spends it.

How magic works: who can cast, spellbooks, Arcana slots and drip, the hand, the cast, burning, ritual, and Defend against hostile workings. Scrolls and potions are at the end. The spell lists live on **[[Burners Spells]]**.

How Magic Works

Magic is prepared, not spontaneous — but the preparation lives in **you**, not in a wand someone can snatch. A Sorcerer exists in two realms at once, and their pack proves it. Utility first — most spells solve problems (light, movement, control, ward); hostile magic lands through the same **Defend** economy as steel. The Sorcerer title (Sorcerie 1) switches casting on; a combat cast is one Action that spends at least L Fuel dice (L = the working’s level) and rolls them for the **cast total**.

Spells Are Cards

Think of every spell you know as a card.

- Your **spellbook** is your your **deck** of known spells. You can have multiple spellbooks in your library.
- Your **hand** is the spells you have prepared to cast.
- Your **Arcana slot count** sets your **hand size**, the number of cards you may hold.
- **Casting** a spell **taps** its card.
- **Burning** a card exiles it to pay for more casting in the same Action.
- After **8 hours of uninterrupted sleep**, you may recover up to your caster level in cards (see *Sleep and recovery*).

Every card in your hand is in exactly one zone. **Tapped, lasting, and burned cards all still occupy hand size** until recovered (or lasting ends).

Zone	Meaning
Ready	In hand, untapped — cast it any time.
Tapped	Cast. In your discard, or <i>in play</i> while a lasting effect runs.
Burned	Exiled as fuel. In your discard, or used as a token.

Lasting is a special case: the card stays *in play* while the effect runs. On sleep redraw or a one-hour swap you may leave lasting cards in place; swapping one out or spending sleep recovery to untap it **ends the effect**.

Tapped and burned are very different fates. A tapped card can be bought back with a burn. A burned card is spent until you rest — you cannot burn a card to recover a burned card, and no working, no gold, no clever reading brings one back early.

One ready name per hand. You cannot hold two *ready* cards for the same spell. A burn-**copy** under an in-play lasting working is allowed — that is not a second ready card.

The Sorcerer

To work magic you must be a **Sorcerer** — **Sorcerie 1 or higher**. Below that you are a layman, and the cards mean nothing in your hands.

Spell level. Your **Sorcerie** is your caster level: you may **learn and know** spells of level up to your Sorcerie. A Sorcerie-1 mage knows only 1st-level spells; a Sorcerie-6 up to 6th. There is no focus ladder — no relic that lets a first-rank sorcerer throw a 6th. The power is in the practitioner.

A school is trained-only. Each of the seven people-schools keeps its own secret language and spell list; you must hold a Trait in that school to touch it at all. The common Sorcerie school asks no Trait — being a Sorcerer is grammar enough.

Canting is the exception. The rogue's school rolls **Craft**, not Sorcerie. A **Journeyman (Craft 1+)** with the **Canting** Trait may learn, hold, and cast Canting only — the Darkman's school — with the same card rules. See Canting: Kicks and Jarks. No Sorcerie required.

Starting Out

The Starting Sorcerer

A Sorcerer's craft comes with a kit (the fruit of apprenticeship). At character creation you **declare 7 physical slots and 5 Arcana slots** — twelve total. You may not re-split until your first 8-hour sleep; we start fast.

Your **personal spellbook** holds **five known spells**: *Read Magic* (always) plus **four others** from your school. The Referee picks them, rolls them, lets you choose, or works with you — your table's call. Your **hand size is 5** and your **hand is all five** — ready to cast. Count them off on your fingers when you onboard; that's the joke.

See *The Starting Sorcerer* under Starting Gear in [[Burners Adventure Game]] for purse and oddments.

The Canting Journeyman

A Journeyman who takes the **Canting** Trait and walks the Canting road declares **7 physical + 5 kicks** (Arcana slots by another name) the same way — but starts with **no spells** in the reader and an **empty hand** of five. Canting is learned in play: guild teaching, stolen manuals, jarks spent or scribed. Other Journeymen keep a normal twelve-slot pack; the split is only for rogues who work Canting magic.

Arcana Slots

You have twelve item slots. As a Sorcerer (or a Canting Journeyman), you **declare a split**: so many slots are **physical**, so many are **Arcana**. Arcana slots hold **Wizard Drip** (or a rogue's kicks) — arcana items, not spells. The **number** of Arcana slots is your **hand size**: how many spells you can hold ready. Your **hand** is separate from inventory and Arcana slots; it is your ready spells, pictured as cards. The cards live in you.

- **Re-split on rest.** On any 8-hour sleep you may redeclare the split. A Sorcerer who wants a six-card hand walks into the dark with six Arcana slots of drip; power is paid for in rope, rations, and armor left behind.
- **Sorcerie caps the spell.** Any card in your hand may be a spell of any level up to your Sorcerie (or Craft, for Canting). Slots are not leveled.
- **Your hand is personal.** No thief, no disarm, no dropped pack parts a caster from their hand. Only sleep, burning, and your own choices move the cards. Losing your spellbook cuts off redraws and swaps — the deck can be taken, the hand cannot.

Initiative. On Roll Initiative, add **one die per Arcana slot** you declared — all of them, empty or filled. Drip riding in those slots does not also add weapon-in-hand dice. Arcana slots **never** also count toward the empty-inventory Initiative dice (max 4).

Wizard Drip

An Arcana slot may carry a physical item — but only **Wizard Drip**: staff, wand, rod, orb, ring, runed robe, talisman, the costume of the craft. Each item costs its **full normal slot cost** (a staff is 3 Arcana slots, not 1).

- Drip keeps its mundane function. A wizard's staff is still a staff — swing it, lean on it, bar a door with it.
- **Never** armor, weapons (beyond the staff's honest whack), shields, or plain cargo. An Arcana slot cannot carry fifty feet of rope. That restriction is the price of the split.
- Losing drip loses an item, nothing more. Steal the archmage's staff and you have stolen a stick. The magic never lived there.
- **Found drip is still drip.** A relic wand, a runed ring, a captured staff — even a full magic item — is just an item if it fits the allow-list. It rides in Arcana slots at its normal slot cost. It does not add a card to your hand, pin a card, or open a spell slot. Whatever power the treasure holds runs as a magic item; your hand is still only spells from your deck.

Casting

No spontaneous magic. You cannot cast a card that is not ready in your hand.

The cast.

1. **Say what you do** — name the spell and its effect in the fiction.
2. **Pay the Cost.** In combat, casting is one Action: commit at least L Fuel dice (L = the working's level) and roll them for the **cast total**, as ever. Out of combat, roll **2d6 + Sorcerie** (or **2d6 + Craft** for Canting) against the Referee's Cost. Sparks, Double Spicy fumbles, and Defending against a spell run as written in [[Burners Adventure Game]].
3. **Tap the card.** An instant working goes to your discard as it resolves. A lasting working stays **in play** for its duration, then joins the discard.

The caster is exposed like anyone taking an Action; struck mid-cast, you defend with Sword like anyone. There is **no special cast penalty** — the hit does not abort the working or force the card to tap.

When a cast Sparks. With a Spark you may spend it on the *working itself* — another target caught, a beat longer, a ward pierced (Referee's call) — or spend up to L additional Fuel dice to push the effect further.

Double Spicy on a combat cast is a fumble — the working goes wrong (the Referee's worst fitting outcome: singe an ally, alert the ward, the card taps with no effect).

Burning

When it comes down to the wire: what will you burn? What won't you need again before you rest?

You may **burn** ready cards from your hand **as part of the same cast Action** — burns and the working together. One Action may burn any number of ready cards (levels covering) **and** resolve a cast, recast, or copy; roll at least L Fuel dice for the working that lands. Burns enable:

- **Recast** a spell in your discard, or
- **Copy** a spell you have in play — a second working alongside the first. Place the burned card face-down beneath the active one to mark the copy (does not break *one ready name*).

The rules of the fire:

- **Hand only.** Fuel comes from ready, uncast cards. You cannot burn from your discard, from play, or from the burned pile.
- **Levels must cover the spell.** The burned cards' levels must sum to **at least** the level of the spell being recast or copied. Several small cards may combine; any overage is wasted.
- **Scrolls never burn.** See [Scrolls](#).
- **Burned is burned** until sleep recovery spends a card from your budget to return it. Burned cards still occupy hand size.

Every card in your hand is a cast — and every card is also fuel for a repeat of something better. You cannot have both.

Sleep and Recovery

After **8 hours of uninterrupted sleep**, you may recover up to **Sorcerie Level** cards (**Craft Level** for Canting) from among your tapped, burned, and lasting cards. That budget is **one pool** — each card you recover costs one card from the budget, whether you are untapping a tapped card or returning a burned one. Spell level does not matter; five 1sts and one 5th both cost one card each.

A character with **both** Sorcerie and Craft (Canting) uses **one hand** and **one split**; the sleep budget is the **higher** of Sorcerie Level and Craft Level.

Recovering a **lasting** card untaps it and **ends the effect**. On redraw you may instead **leave lasting cards in place** (see *Changing Your Hand*).

On the same sleep you may **re-split** physical vs Arcana slots and **redraw your hand** (see below).

Changing Your Hand

Choosing or changing the cards in your hand requires a **readable source** — your spellbook, or a captured grimoire you can read (see *Spellbooks*).

- **Rest: full redraw.** On an 8-hour sleep with a readable source in reach, rebuild your hand freely from your deck — any known spells, up to your caster level, one per hand slot, unique by name. You may **keep lasting cards in play**; swapping one out or spending sleep recovery on it **ends the effect**.
- **One hour: swap one card.** With an hour of study and the source in hand, exchange one card in your hand for one from your deck. **The incoming card inherits the outgoing card's status** — swap out a tapped card and the new card arrives tapped. Swapping out a lasting card **ends its effect**.

Scrolls

A **scroll** is a single-use working — **not** a card. One spell, already written: parchment, feather, wax seal, charm on a string — call it a scroll either way. **1 slot** each; it may ride in a **physical or Arcana** slot.

- **Cast** it as any spell of that level: one Action in combat, at least L Fuel dice for the cast total — then it is **spent** (ash, blank vellum, snapped charm). Your **hand is untouched**; no card taps.
- **Cast only.** A scroll can never be burned as fuel.
- **Who may cast:** a **Sorcerer**, or a **Journeyman** for Canting scrolls — you need the school's Trait (or Canting). A Veteran cannot wake one. *Read Magic* identifies it before you spend it.
- **Scribing** (downtime): **100 gp × the spell's level** in reagents, from any spell you hold in a readable source — same gold as moving a spell into your book. You may unmake a scroll into your book (same cost and time); the scroll is destroyed without being cast.

Spell level on scroll	Cost to scribe (gp)
1	100
2	200
3	300
4	400
5	500
6	600

Potions

A **potion** is a single-use draught — **not** a card, **not** drip. Downtime work. If you have a **Vitae** Trait, or **Craft** with herbalism or alchemy, you may brew a potion from a known formula — a Vitae working you hold in a readable source, or another recipe the Referee grants. Cost: **100 gp × the spell’s level** in reagents and about a week × its level. Touch or self effects only — what a draught can hold. The potion is one dose, **1 physical slot** (never Arcana — potions are not Wizard Drip); **anyone may drink it**. Recipe and gold decide it — no Sorcerie rank required. Found potions stay treasure.

Ritual Casting

A spell **learned into your own book** can be worked straight from an **open readable source** — your book, or another book you can read that holds that same working — no card, but slowly, rooted in place, and only while you sustain it. Found-book spells you have memorized into your hand but not yet scribed are for the hand and redraw only; they are **not** ritual fodder until they live in your personal book. Ten minutes per spell level; leave the circle or close the book and the working collapses retroactively. What a ritual puts in your *mind* stays. Ritual casting taps nothing and burns nothing; the cost is time and stillness. Never a combat option.

Knowledge is the exception. Whatever a spell puts in your *mind* stays — *Detect Magic*’s auras, a divination’s answer, anything the Referee judges is now simply known.

Spellbooks

Your deck is a book, and a book can be lost.

- **Personal spellbook** — 1 physical slot. Holds every spell you have scribed into it. Left in camp, your deck is out of reach: no redraws, no swaps until you are reunited. Margins hold **Facts** (scraps, runes, puzzles) — free in plain ink; they are not workings until you spend reagent ink to fix them.
- **Readable sources (OSE).** A captured grimoire is written so only its owner can read it without magic. Cast or work *Read Magic* on the writing; thereafter you can always read that script. While you **carry** the source, you may treat spells in it as **known** for redraw and swap — memorize from the book at hand, as classic OSE. Drop it or leave it in town and those spells leave your ready library until you recover the source or scribe them into your own book.
- **Moving a spell into your book.** Copy it: **100 gp × level** in reagent inks and about a week × its level. No roll. **This destroys the written source** you copied from (page, exemplar, or scroll unmade into the book). A living teacher is not destroyed; you still pay ink and time to scribe what they teach.
- **Copies within your library** — **25 gp × level** and a day × level; your first book is not destroyed.

Item	Slots	Cost (gp)
Spellbook, blank	1	25
Scroll case	1	5

Item	Slots	Cost (gp)
Reagent inks (move a spell into your book)	—	100 × level
Reagent inks (copy within your library)	—	25 × level
Make a scroll	1	100 × level
Brew a potion	1	100 × level

Canting: Kicks and Jarks

Rogues on the Canting road split their twelve slots the same way — but a rogue would never say *Arcana*.

- An Arcana slot is a **kick** — a secret pocket sewn where honest folk carry rope. “*How many kicks you running tonight?*”
- The spellbook is the **reader** — the pocketbook of the trade, written in flash paper and brotherhood marks.
- A scroll is a **jark** — a counterfeit seal, primed and single-use, spent when flashed.

All the card rules apply: **Craft** is caster level in place of Sorcerie; hand size is kick count; tapping, burning, and sleep run identically. **Canting Trait** opens the school; you need not be a Sorcerer. A character who also has Sorcerie still runs **one hand** and **one split**; sleep recovery uses the **higher** of Sorcerie and Craft.

Canting drip is different in the fiction — a lot more black. Kicks hold the working kit: rope, picks, a dark lantern, a betty, chalk, a muffler, soft-soled stampers — anything **concealable** under a coat. Nothing that shines, nothing that rattles.

- **No weapons, armor, or shields** in a kick — with the burglar’s exception: a **knife**, a **sap**, or a **sling** may hide there.
- A searched rogue looks like a burglar, not a mage. That is the point.

Spells meshing with combat

Each spell has a name, level, and effect on [[Burners Spells]] — run it as written unless this chapter, the spell list, or the Referee says otherwise. Where a spell’s effect must mesh with combat:

- **HP and damage** that target a creature come off HP. Physical effects may be soaked by AC after Defend (see [[Burners Principles#Harm and effect are separate lanes]]).
- **Hostile magic** is opposed with **Defend** — Fuel dice vs the caster’s cast total. A hostile cast where no fight is yet underway still rolls initiative. Choose whichever Approach fits; a spell may suggest one (*Defend: Sword*). Procedure: *Defending against a spell* below.
- **Control** (charm, sleep, fear, command...) uses the effect lane, not HP — see [[Burners Principles#Harm and effect are separate lanes]].

Defending against a spell

See [[Burners Principles#Granular defense, not binary save]] and [[Burners Principles#Harm and effect are separate lanes]].

When a spell targets you with harm, control, or another hostile effect, the caster’s **cast total** is the sum of the Fuel dice spent to cast (at least L dice for a level-L working).

Roll initiative. A hostile spell is an attack like any other. If no fight is yet underway, roll initiative — the caster gains no free first strike.

You may **Defend** as against any blow: commit Fuel dice, roll them, sum the faces. Those dice are spent for the fight. Your **defense total** opposes the cast total. Choose whichever Approach fits; the spell may suggest one (*Defend: Sword*, *Defend: Heart*, and so on). Commit as many Fuel dice as you choose — no cap.

Warding. Any **Sorcerer** (Sorcerie 1+) adjacent to an ally or a tight group may **Ward** hostile magic aimed at them — a spell’s cast total, magical breath, and the like (not mundane fire alone). Commit up to your **Sorcerie Level** in Fuel dice; subtract their sum from the attack value. **Each ally then Defends normally** against what remains. No school Trait; no card. Craft-only Canting Journeymen cannot Ward. See *Ward* in [\[\[Burners Adventure Game\]\]](#).

- **Defense ≥ cast:** fully defended — no effect, no HP loss.
- **Defense < cast:** **overrun** = cast – defense. Apply per the harm/effect lanes above.

Spells with no hostile target (light on a wall, healing a willing ally, reading magic) allow no Defend. Area workings: each target Defends separately against the same cast total.

Reading Magic

Literacy and deeper probe are one working: **Read Magic** (Sorcerie 1 — always known to every Sorcerer). See its entry on [\[\[Burners Spells\]\]](#).

If you have a Trait in a magic school you are a practitioner of it: literate in its abstruse language up to your level. In a school you are trained in you read the plain words of its writing for free — see the runes, count them, know their literal meanings; the script of a school you hold no Trait in is chicken-scratch until *Read Magic* deciphers it.

Cast or work *Read Magic* to open foreign script (found books, scrolls, glyphs). Once you have read a book’s hand, you can always read that script again. Optionally go deeper: studying a writing or item is an Action; describe how deep you probe. Interpretation is a Step-2 risk — the deeper the reading, the steeper the Cost (HP, time, noise, or a Spicy twist). Roll it out (Sorcerie, out of danger). On a success the Referee reveals one **Fact** at the depth you reached — a power (what it does), a demand (what it costs), or an omen (what changes about the bearer or world). On a **Sweet** you fully grasp it and a revealed power can be called on demand; on a **Spicy** the reading misleads or trips the power wrongly.

Track each magical item as two short lists, filled in as study and play reveal them: **Facts** (established truths) and **Questions** (open threads). A Fact scribbled here is the same kind of note as a spell-scrap in your book — free to record; to work the spell you still need a readable source (or to move it into your book).

What Sorcerie is for

Sorcerie	Role
0	Cannot cast
1+	Sorcerer — magic on; may Ward
Higher	Caster level: learn higher-level spells (up to level = Sorcerie); stronger Sorcerie rolls; sleep recovery budget = Sorcerie Level in cards (or higher of Sorcerie/Craft if both)

See [\[\[Burners Spells\]\]](#) for the school lists and every working.